From the Archaic to the Classical Periods

During the Archaic period (800 – 500 BCE), kings were gradually replaced by republics. Athens introduced democracy, with single city states instead of larger regions and the first Greek coins were created. Furthermore, this period also saw the establishment of the iconic pottery and sculpture Ancient Greece is known for. It established a foundation for the new Classical period (480 – 323 BCE), also known as the golden age of Athens. Pericles ordered the construction of the grand Acropolis, which still looks down upon Athens today. He gave his renowned speech where he honored the men who fell while defending the city against the Persians at the Battle of Marathon. The country saw great developments in all areas including the arts, philosophy, sciences and education. Many famous individuals such as Plato and Aristophanes left their mark during this era. In 480 BCE, King Leonidas and his legendary 300 Spartans were defeated at Thermopylae. Themistocles was victorious over the Persian navy at Salamis, which caused the Persians to be completely defeated at Plataea the following year.

Also, the first democratic state was born at Athens. Democracy is made up of the Greek words *Demos*, which means people, and *Kratos*, which means power. Men over 20 years old were allowed to vote for the government. Also, philosophers including the likes of Thales appeared during this time and began to voice their philosophies regarding the natural world. Pythagoras, Xenophanes and Anaximander renewed pre-conceived ideas about the cosmos and presented theories explaining the emergence of the world.

Those who followed, including Archimedes, carried on with these investigations and eventually founded formal mathematics. Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle developed their works such that they had great impact on Greece and the rest of the world. Architecture and art styles continued to progress while moving away from the idyllic and turning towards the truthful. The Parthenon marbles derive from this period and although they feature mythical beings, they are shown in a much more realistic light as compared to earlier periods.